How to Reset the MySQL Root Password on Windows

A Simple Guide for MySQL 8.0, 8.4, and 9.6

Technical Instructional Guide

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This guide explains how to reset a forgotten MySQL root password on Windows using PowerShell and a temporary SQL initialization file. The steps are similar for MySQL 8.0, 8.4, and 9.6. Commands assume a standard installation; verify actual service names and folders before running them (Oracle, n.d.-a, n.d.-b, n.d.-c).

Before You Begin

Sign in with a Windows administrator account. Back up important databases if possible. Do not delete the MySQL Data folder, run mysqld --initialize, or share the new password. MySQL must be stopped before starting a temporary server against the same data directory.

Step 1: Find and Stop Your MySQL Service

```
Get-Service *mysql*
```

Record the service name shown (for example, MySQL80, MySQL84, or MySQL96). These names are examples, not guarantees. Then inspect its startup configuration:

```
sc.exe qc <ServiceName>
```

Replace <ServiceName> with the actual name; the BINARY_PATH_NAME line identifies the server executable and may show the --defaults-file path. Stop the service:

```
Stop-Service -Name "<ServiceName>"
```

```
Get-Service -Name "<ServiceName>"
```

Proceed only when the status says Stopped.

Step 2: Create the Password Reset File

Open Notepad as Administrator. Enter exactly one SQL statement on one line, replacing the sample password with your own strong, unique password:

```
ALTER USER 'root'@'localhost' IDENTIFIED BY
'Choose_A_Strong_New_Password';
```

Save as C:\mysql-init.txt (Save as type: All Files). Keep this file private because it contains the new password in plain text. Verify it and your actual configuration file:

```
Test-Path "C:\mysql-init.txt"
```

Use Test-Path with the exact my.ini path from sc.exe qc. Both files must exist before you continue.

Step 3: Select Commands for Your MySQL Version

In Administrator PowerShell, run the two lines for your installed version. If your service lists a different --defaults-file path, replace the example config path with that exact location. The commands use full executable paths, so a PATH update or changing directories is unnecessary.

MySQL 8.0

```
$exe = "C:\Program Files\MySQL\MySQL Server 8.0\bin\mysqld.exe"
```

```
$config = "C:\ProgramData\MySQL\MySQL Server 8.0\my.ini"
```

After checking that $config matches the installed Windows service and exists, run:

```
& $exe --defaults-file="$config" --init-file="C:\mysql-init.txt" --console
```

Keep this PowerShell window open while the temporary server is running.

MySQL 8.4

```
$exe = "C:\Program Files\MySQL\MySQL Server 8.4\bin\mysqld.exe"
$config = "C:\ProgramData\MySQL\MySQL Server 8.4\my.ini"
```

After checking that $config matches the installed Windows service and exists, run:

```
& $exe --defaults-file="$config" --init-file="C:\mysql-init.txt" --console
```

Keep this PowerShell window open while the temporary server is running.

MySQL 9.6

```
$exe = "C:\Program Files\MySQL\MySQL Server 9.6\bin\mysqld.exe"
$config = "C:\ProgramData\MySQL\MySQL Server 9.6\my.ini"
```

After checking that $config matches the installed Windows service and exists, run:

```
& $exe --defaults-file="$config" --init-file="C:\mysql-init.txt" --console
```

Keep this PowerShell window open while the temporary server is running.

Step 4: Check Startup and Test the New Password

The output should include “ready for connections” with no errors about the initialization file. That message alone does not verify the password change. Open a second PowerShell window and enter the command for your installed version:

MySQL 8.0:

& "C:\Program Files\MySQL\MySQL Server 8.0\bin\mysql.exe" -u root -p

MySQL 8.4:

& "C:\Program Files\MySQL\MySQL Server 8.4\bin\mysql.exe" -u root -p

MySQL 9.6:

& "C:\Program Files\MySQL\MySQL Server 9.6\bin\mysql.exe" -u root -p

When prompted, type the NEW root password. If the mysql> prompt appears, the reset succeeded. Run SELECT CURRENT_USER(), VERSION(); and then EXIT; to close the client.

Step 5: Remove the File and Restart Normally

After a successful password test, stop the temporary MySQL server in its first PowerShell window using Ctrl+C, and wait until it shuts down. Delete the plaintext reset file and start your normal Windows service:

Remove-Item "C:\mysql-init.txt"

Start-Service -Name "<ServiceName>"

Get-Service -Name "<ServiceName>"

Verify that the service is Running; connect again using mysql.exe -u root -p or update your saved connection in MySQL Workbench/DBeaver.

Common Problems

“mysqld is not recognized”: In PowerShell, use .\mysqld.exe from the bin folder, or the full executable path as shown here.

“Failed to open required defaults file”: The specified my.ini location is wrong or inaccessible. Read sc.exe qc <ServiceName> and confirm the file exists.

“Permission denied” for the Data directory: Confirm Administrator PowerShell. Check folder access and the configured service account; do not modify permissions or recreate the data directory without diagnosing the cause.

“ERROR 2003 (10061)”: No MySQL server is accepting connections on that address/port. Check Get-Service and server startup messages; this is not proof of a bad password.

“Access denied for user root”: Ensure the server is running, the correct account is root@localhost, and the reset SQL executed successfully.

Security reminder: Never include a real password in screenshots, emails, or shared notes. The temporary init file must be deleted after verification.

References

Oracle. (n.d.-a). How to reset the root password (MySQL 8.0 Reference Manual). https://dev.mysql.com/doc/refman/8.0/en/resetting-permissions.html

Oracle. (n.d.-b). How to reset the root password (MySQL 8.4 Reference Manual). https://dev.mysql.com/doc/refman/8.4/en/resetting-permissions.html

Oracle. (n.d.-c). How to reset the root password (MySQL Reference Manual; the 9.6 link redirects to current 9.7 documentation). https://dev.mysql.com/doc/refman/9.6/en/resetting-permissions.html